

Inquiries in Sociology

Session 3 - How to: Develop Your Research Design and Empirical Methods

Sciences Po Le Havre - 23/09/2025

Quentin LACMARI

PhD Student in Sociology (CERI - Sciences Po)

How to: Develop Your Research Design and Empirical Methods - Summary

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Method Design

- Why conducting a fieldwork? Linking empirical material with theory
- Qualitative fieldwork and its methods

Ethics and Fieldwork: For a Contextualised Approach

- Identifying risks in context
- Qualitative research and ethics

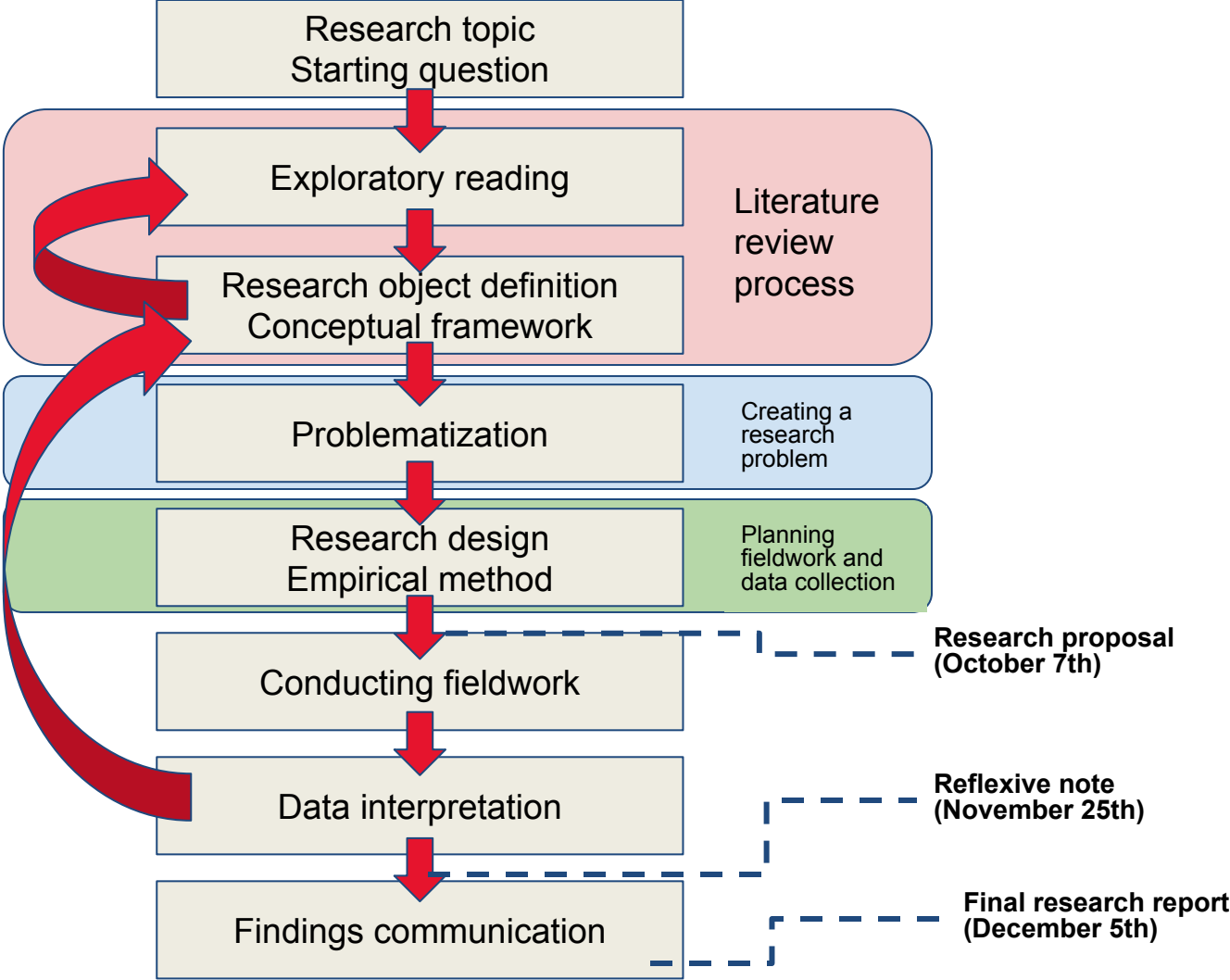
In-Class Activity: Prepare Your Research Proposal

- Methodological guidelines for writing a research proposal
- Groups supervision on your project advancement

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Method

Linking Empiry with Theory in
Your Research Design

Research
Project Outline



From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Why conducting fieldwork? Linking empirical material with theory

- “*To theorize as a sociologist is always to **theorize from empirical material** [...]. Without empirical boundaries, theory has no means of discovering the limits of its own relevance.*” (Lahire 2018, 63)
 - Social sciences are neither purely theoretical (speculative) nor a plain description of the *reality* of the world (empiricism)
 - “*Social reality can only be grasped through an intellectual elaboration that offers an understanding of it in a perpetual back-and-forth between empirical observation and conceptual construction*” (Hibou 2021, 2)
- Research design integrates both problematization and research object construction with the production of empirical data that supports it (i.e. your fieldwork strategy and methodology).

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Why conducting fieldwork? Linking empirical material with theory

- There exists a **mythification of the fieldwork site** as a privileged space and moment in research where the task is to "uncover" a hidden reality, inaccessible to uninitiated observers and, even more problematically, to the very subjects of the research themselves.
- However, B. Hibou (2021) consider “the field as a cognitive site”, a set of reflections which, based on empirical elements and difficulties, enable us to constantly refine and rework our research problem and objects.
 - Fieldwork fuels conceptual elaboration: research is an iterative process
 - Fieldwork actually “overflows” the delimited period when you directly interact with your participants

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Why conducting fieldwork? Linking empirical material with theory

- This heuristic approach to fieldwork highlights the need for adaptive conceptual frameworks and resilient research designs, where **the evolution of your problematization is shaped by the empirical and historical contexts of your inquiry.**
- This dynamic process, in turn, grounds your methodological planning and reflexive engagement.

“From this perspective[...] ‘sources’ are not primarily valued for the information they provide, information that could often be obtained elsewhere and that, in any case, must be verified, cross-checked, reworked, and confronted with other data to yield meaning. Rather, [...] **sources help construct reality by refining and giving concrete substance to theories and concepts, [...] sometimes even challenging or relativizing them, or opening new horizons.** They do so through their confrontation with the researcher—a confrontation of perspectives, reasoning, doubts, and uncertainties—and through the detours they compel the researcher to take, thereby contributing to the refinement or creation of problematics, the emergence of new themes, and the recognition of the need for new conceptualizations.” (Hibou 2021, 11)

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

How to produce qualitative empirical data? Discussion from the texte Olivier De Sardan, Jean-Pierre. « The Policy of Fieldwork: Data Production in Anthropology and Qualitative Approaches », 2015.

- From which discipline does Jean-Pierre Olivier de Sardan come?
- What are the different objectives of quantitative (survey) and qualitative methods (ethnographic)?
 - What does the validity of those methods (rigor) rely on?
 - « Fieldwork is above all a matter of know-how; it uses intuition, improvisation, and tinkering (bricolage). » (Olivier De Sardan, 2015, p. 24) - Can we make sciences using “intuition, improvisation and tinkering” ?
- What are the six methods of data production presented in the text?
 - Which one(s) would you consider using in your project?
 - Why using the term “data production” instead of “data collection”?
- What biases could you identify in qualitative methods? How to correct them?

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Qualitative fieldwork and its methods

- Quantitative inquiries operates within the limited and artificial context of questioning from a standardized survey on a randomly chosen and representative group.
- Qualitative inquiries via ethnographic methods aims at understand the actors' point of view by producing *in situ* and contextualized knowledge over an already existing group (though it can be analytically reconstructed)

Table 2.1 Field inquiry and inquiry through questionnaires

<i>Field inquiry</i>	<i>Inquiry through questionnaires</i>
broad, multidimensional, noncodable information	circumscribed, univocal, codable information
artisanal processing	statistical processing
natural situations or situations close to natural situations (conversation)	artificial situations (interrogation)
researcher in person	paid investigators
immersion in the milieu	sporadic interaction
information on contextualized processes and logics (without statistical representativeness)	information on decontextualized variables (statistical representativeness)
intensive, duration, returns	extensive, brevity, linearity
research trails, iteration, improvisation	verifiable, precise hypotheses
many intertwined variables	dependent/independent variables

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

What is qualitative data?

- “All data [...] arise from interactions between the researcher and the social milieus he studies.” They give rise to handwritten or electronic traces, which may be treated and analyzed at a later date. Each corpus is created based on procedures combining improvisation, coherence, and systematic methodology.” (Olivier de Sardan 2015, 27)
- Data cannot refer to pure “fragments of reality” the researcher would conserve (positivist illusion): they are a selection of traces (of “clues”) used to objectify a “fragment of reality” analyzed by the researcher.
- Different manners of looking at a social milieu will produce different types of data under different formats

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Familiarization and researcher's participation in the field

- Participant observation:
 - By immersing him/herself in the situations he/she intend to study, the researcher gains a deeper understanding of the context of its inquiry (local signifiante, social groups and hierarchies, social representations, etc.).
 - A way to produce recorded and/or un-recorded data from interviews, conversations or observations (fieldnotes).
 - Those interaction play an important role in the “familiarization” of the researcher that helps decode the actions and words of the social actors he/she studies:
 - “It’s deep familiarity that is the rationale—that, plus getting material on a tissue of events—that provides the justification of such an apparently ‘loose’ thing as fieldwork” (Goffman, 1989: 130).

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Different methods of qualitative fieldwork: Interviews

- Interviews can complete observations by accessing to “local knowledge” and representations via *emic discourses*.
 - The interviewee is then considered both a “consultant”, as expert of the social knowledge he detains, and “subject” questioned for his lived experiences;
- The interview as an interaction to analyze in itself (body language, the place, the way you contacted your participant, ...)
- There is a necessity to transform the researcher’s questions into questions that make sense to the interlocutor; empathy and familiarity plays an important role.

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Different methods of qualitative fieldwork: Observation

- The observation “from outside”, without interacting with the milieu under study, present a risks of naturalism and positivism (‘aquarium effect’); though it is useful in combination of other means of data production (during interview and conversations)
 - Experience from my own fieldwork on:
 - What did I used it for?
 - Attempt to systematize observations (places, hours, recording)
 - The risk of becoming invisible and to overcome it

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Different methods of qualitative fieldwork: mixing data production

- Other sources and data combination:
 - Microsurvey (p.38-39) as a mean of “etic” data production for comparison with *emic* data (produced through interviews and discussions for instance)
 - Documentary sources (p.39-40) - academic literature, “grey literature”, archives, press, *local* written documents (produced by the actors)
 - Audiovisual Sources (p.40-41) - the corpus selection and production must be justified, useful though “still experimental” (example of delivery vlogs)
- Why looking for “data eclecticism” (p.41-42)
 - Those types of data “naturally” exist in synergy in the studied *milieu* (there shouldn’t be any hierarchy between them from an analytical standpoint). They might unveil different aspects of the sociological problem you’re willing to investigate. Be open to those empirical material and reflect on what aspect they might highlight or mask.

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Thinking Your Research as a Case Study

- There is no need to justify the case study in advance based on ‘objective’ comparison criteria – that is not how you chose your subjects – it is sufficient to explain (to the reader) after the fact what this case reveals, what it shows, and what it allows us to think about your topic.

“A field case, even in its ‘micro’ version, even in the event of in-depth study for its own sake, even when it is not included in a corpus of cases aimed at comparison, even if it does not generate fresh theorization, always alludes to something larger than itself, beyond itself: a larger set, a broader social context, other cases, a research theme, a problematic. It works as a revealer, descriptor, indicator, symptom, or example.” (Olivier de Sardan 2015 [1995], 43-44)

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Qualitative fieldwork and its methods: rigor and “the policy of fieldwork”

- **Breaking free from hypothesis:**
 - Fieldwork does not allow us to explain the causality between dependent and independent variables that have been established in advance! It consists of exploring “trails” and describing phenomena whose connections will be revealed during the analysis/interpretation of this field data in order to answer the question (which will have evolved).
- **Triangulation of data:**
 - This involves comparing different discourses/representations of the social world in order to explain/understand them (not to say which is true and which is false) – for example, a widely held belief among delivery drivers in Amman is that there has never been, or almost never been, any mobilisation; however, the press has covered several delivery driver strike movements over the last three years.
 - Thanks to triangulation, you might understand the formation and power relations between “strategic groups” that form around a certain social, economical, political problem. By structuring your fieldwork milieu in terms of strategic groups, you may explain previous paradoxical observations and discourses (look for interviewing dissident or clashing opinions).

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

Qualitative fieldwork and its methods: rigor and “the policy of fieldwork”

- **Use reflexivity** and acknowledge your explicit iterative interpretation process:
 - Researcher’s subjectivity calls for objectification via reflexivity (in field diary, collective cross-check)
- **Constructing “describers”**:
 - Design observable elements upon which your interpretation will be based - sorts of “indicators” - in an iterative manner.
- **Managing “biases”** while producing data:
 - Identify behavioral modification due to researcher’s presence;
 - Be careful not to get caught up in cliques (“*encliquage*”);
 - Keeping a clear distinction between the participants’ statements and the researcher’s interpretation;
 - over/undue indication of representativeness caused by extrapolation and generalization;

From a Research Problem to an Empirical Design

How to design your qualitative research method? What do I expect from your work?

- In your research proposal, design your empirical method in reference to the field/the case you want to study
 - What empirical data have you found already to define your research problem? What does it say about the context of the people you want to investigate?
 - How did you (or the literature) conceptually define your research object(s)? What do you think would be an appropriate method to grasp your object(s) empirically?
 - What are the “trails” (hypotheses) that lead you to your research question? How would you test them?
- In your fieldwork, stay open to the unexpected (that’s what you should look for!). Fieldwork and re-conceptualization are interdependent and simultaneous. Be flexible and keep track of those unexpected elements and transformations, you will use them to reflect on your research process.

Any questions?

Ethical Stakes of Fieldwork

Deontology and Duties of the
Researcher in Human Sciences

Ethics and Fieldwork

What is at stakes when conducting qualitative fieldwork?

- What main ethical stakes would you identify in conducting qualitative fieldwork?
- Are deontological regulations in social science research useful?
- You are a French researcher investigating the political dynamics of a precarious group of workers in a non-Western country. After 40 minutes of interview, a participant ask you if you planned on paying him for the time he is spending answering your question.
 - What would be your answer?
 - What elements of context do you think is important in this decision?

Ethics and Fieldwork

For a contextual ethical policy in research

- (Fujii 2008) In “micro-level inquiry” (that involves direct and intense engagement from the research on its fieldwork), the “do no-harm” regulation is ineffective if not adapted to the specific risks of the inquiry context.
 - On anonymity - How to guarantee that your participants can not be identified?
 - Introducing yourself and presenting your research - What strategies?
 - Transparency and consistency - How to prove good-faith and respect participants' consent?
 - Positionality - What are the power relations between the researcher and his/her participants? How does that shape the inquiry?
 - Understanding the effect of your presence in the milieu - How do people represent your research? How do they see your participants?
 - Presenting your research - What are the impact of the publication of your research? What would your participants think of what you wrote?

Ethics and Fieldwork

What is expected in terms of ethical “policy” in your research design?

- You must anticipate ethical risks in your research design:
 - Precautionary principle is key to ensure that you won't do harm, it is the researcher(s) primary responsibility
 - Get the maximum informations about the social context of your participants in order to adapt your research design and ethical precautions as best you can
- While conducting your fieldwork:
 - Pay attention to the reactions you may cause while interacting with participants
 - Preserve anonymity of your participants as much as possible
 - Be clear, consistent and reassuring all along your fieldwork
 - Make sure you get a real informed consent from your participant (as a way of engaging them informally in your research)
 - Be sensitive, show empathy and never judge your participants' opinion or experience
- After you produced your data:
 - Be honest and respectful of the words of your participants
 - Keep in mind that they might read your work afterward - depending on the context, you could consider a form of restitution of you research if you think it could be beneficial

Any questions?

Prepare Your Research Proposal (a detailed plan)

In-class activity

Prepare Your Research Proposal

What is a research proposal?

- Document's format: 2,000 words ($\pm 20\%$), including bibliography.
- Aim: Defend the interest of your research topic and question (is that topic worth investigating?). Convince your research supervisor that you are sufficiently prepared to start your fieldwork.
- Document's structure
 - An **introduction** to your research topic with some contextual background, a presentation of different facts and interpretations from the literature that are relevant to your research problem.
 - **Problematization**, by building up your research puzzle (e.g. a contradiction, a paradox or a gap) and formulating a preliminary research question.
 - A presentation of your **literature review** and conceptual framework - what has been written that could help you answer your question? How will you frame your research object to answer your question? Which concepts (tools) will you use, and why?
 - A discussion of your **methodology** and the feasibility of your fieldwork. Present your fieldwork plan (where, with whom and how) and justify it by explaining the data you are looking for to answer your research question.
 - You may also wish to add a short section discussing the **expected contribution** of your project.
 - The **bibliography** is also a very important part of your research proposal! Make sure you quote your references properly.

Prepare Your Research Proposal

What is a research proposal?

- For feedbacks, prepare a detailed plan of your research proposal for next session (send it by email preferably before monday)
- The real graded one is due to October 7th (one deposit on Moodle per group) + you will present it orally to the class for your first academic workshop on October 14th

For the next session (September 23rd)

- **Start reading on your research topic and think of a research question**
- **Read the mandatory text from Olivier de Sardan (2015), “The Policy of Fieldwork”**